

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 173

Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 7 Wanoi: The Many Facets Of A Midwife

When I saw people going toward the field, I sent the goats into the bush, then gathered *mathakwa* [leaves] because I was told by my grandmother that a girl being circumcised sits on such leaves. After collecting them, I went to the field and reached there just when the other girl—my friend—was being circumcised. I quickly put down the *mathakwa* leaves and sat down on them with my legs spread. I didn't even have a supporter! After being cut, women took me home.

159
Life History Materials

881
Puberty And Initiation

I went home slowly, slowly, with women of my clan on either side of me, holding me and dancing and singing. When I got home, I found my mother had gone away somewhere to drink beer where people were celebrating the *Irua* season. But I met my father's eldest brother, whom I called *Baba*. He told me that as I had braved the ceremony without a supporter, he would give me a goat. So you see my bravery is not recent. I was brave even a long time ago.

159
Life History Materials

881
Puberty And Initiation

When I entered the compound, people remembered that my father had never beaten my mother, so they went to look for her. You see, it was the custom that a mother should be beaten on the day that her first child gets circumcised if she had never been beaten before. So when my mother finally got home, my father found some *mukenia* [type of plant], and he beat my mother before I was allowed to go into the house. My mother and father were surprised to find me circumcised, but they did not show it.

159
Life History Materials

881
Puberty And Initiation

I did not stay long in the house before I was taken outside behind and the clotted blood was removed from the cuts and they were washed with warm water. Then castor oil was put on *ithangu*, and it was put over the wound. I stayed for three days, and then my head was shaved, and as I was the first

159
Life History Materials

881
Puberty And Initiation

daughter of my mother, her head was shaved, too. It took me three months to heal.

How did I feel after going for *Irua*? was like being given a degree for going from childhood to womanhood. One became mature. It was very important in those days, because when one got circumcised, one would not joke about with uncircumcised girls and they would give us respect. If I got circumcised a year earlier than you, you would not be able to abuse me. If one refused *Irua*, she was beaten by others, abused, and would not have anybody visiting her home looking for her to marry. But the minute you got circumcised no one would stand in your way—you were ready to marry.

159

[Life History Materials](#)

881

[Puberty And Initiation](#)

Once circumcised, a young woman could talk and joke with young, uncircumcised men, but we did not move with them sexually until one got married. But now, my small daughter Karuana [aged ten] knows things about sex, and even Njeri [daughter, aged twenty] knows, even though she is uncircumcised.

159

[Life History Materials](#)

832

[Sexual Stimulation](#)

And another thing, there are no *mariika* today. The girls who went for *Irua* stayed friends and would talk until dark, asking each other questions about the day and joking with each other. People knew which age group they belonged to and what behaviors were good for their age group. Nowadays, there is no difference between age groups. That is why children are so naughty—there is no way they know when they are grown up, because circumcision is no longer practiced among the girls. *Irua* meant becoming a member of a *riika* and learning Agikũyũ traditions, but after *Uhuru*, people started saying that Mary in the Bible was not circumcised, so why should we? That is when *Irua* started losing its meaning. I would not like to see girls circumcised now, but if the old people are to be believed, *Irua* would come back.

159

[Life History Materials](#)

178

[Sociocultural Trends](#)

881

[Puberty And Initiation](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)